

Stirling Castle - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Castle That Was the Key to Scotland

There's an old saying: whoever holds Stirling holds Scotland. Here's why. Look out from the castle walls at the flat land below, called the carse. For centuries, that land was boggy marsh, and Stirling had the lowest safe bridge over the River Forth. Every army marching between the south of Scotland and the Highlands had to squeeze through this exact spot — like the neck of an hourglass — right under this castle's guns. That's why Scotland's two most famous battles happened within sight of these walls. In 1297, William Wallace — you might know him from the movie *Braveheart*, though the movie made up quite a lot — waited until the English army was halfway across the narrow wooden bridge, then attacked, defeating a much bigger force. You can see the Wallace Monument tower on the hill across the valley. Then, in 1314, Robert the Bruce beat the English again at Bannockburn, just south of here, in the battle that won Scotland's independence. The day before the main battle, an English knight spotted Bruce on a small pony, ahead of his army, and charged him with a lance. Bruce waited... sidestepped at the last second... and finished the fight with one axe blow. His commanders scolded him for risking everything. Bruce reportedly just complained that he'd broken his good axe.

The Trap at Stirling Bridge

Let me tell you exactly how a small Scottish army beat a huge English one, right down there below the castle. Look for the winding river and imagine, instead of the stone bridge you see today, a narrow wooden one, so skinny that only two horses could cross it side by side. In the year 1297, an English army came marching to that bridge. Waiting on the far side, up on the wooded hill where the tall Wallace Monument now stands, were two Scottish leaders. One was William Wallace. The other you may never have heard of, because history is unfair. His name was Andrew Moray, and he was just as clever as Wallace, maybe cleverer.

Here was their plan, and it was beautifully simple. A bridge lets soldiers across only a few at a time, like sand trickling through the neck of an hourglass. So the Scots waited. They watched the English tramp across, slowly, slowly. They did not panic. They did not charge too early. And when about half the enemy had crossed, and half was still stuck on the other side, the Scots came roaring down the hill and seized the end of the bridge. Now the English army was cut in two. The half that had crossed was trapped in a bend of the river with no way back, and the half still waiting could only stand and watch their friends being beaten. They could not help. The bridge was blocked.

One of the men who died that day was an Englishman named Hugh de Cressingham, a tax collector so greedy and so hated that when the battle was over, the story goes, the Scots peeled off his skin and cut it into strips to keep as souvenirs. Yuck, and also, that is how much they disliked their taxes.

Here is the sad part. Andrew Moray, the clever co-leader, was badly wounded in the battle and died a few weeks later. Because he did not live to fight more battles, most people forgot him, and remembered only Wallace. So next time you hear the name William Wallace, whisper Andrew Moray too. He helped win the trap at the river, the day a bridge became the deadliest weapon in Scotland.

Bannockburn and the Castle on a Volcano

Now look south, to the flatter ground with the little stream running through it. That is Bannockburn, where in the summer of 1314 Robert the Bruce fought the biggest army England had ever sent north, and won. Here is how you beat a giant. You do not meet him where he is strong. You choose the ground.

Bruce picked soft, boggy land, criss-crossed by streams, exactly the sort of place where heavy warhorses sink and stumble. Then his men did something sneaky. The night before, they dug hundreds of hidden pits in the ground and covered them with sticks and grass, little traps for galloping horses to break their legs in. And when the fighting came, the Scots stood shoulder to shoulder in huge circles bristling with long spears, pointing out in every direction like a giant hedgehog. These formations had a name, the schiltron. A charging horse will not run onto a wall of spear points. It just will not. So the English cavalry crashed and milled about and got squeezed backward, tighter and tighter, into the boggy streams, until the whole enormous army was jammed together and beaten.

The English king, Edward the Second, ran for his life, and here is the delicious part. He galloped straight to this castle, Stirling, hammering to be let in. And the man in charge of the castle said no. He would not open the gate, because the castle was about to be handed over to the Scots anyway. Imagine being a king, chased off a battlefield, and having the door shut in your face by your own side.

Now, one more thing to know about where you are standing. This whole castle sits on top of a volcano. Don't worry, it went cold and dead millions and millions of years ago. Long, long afterwards, giant sheets of ice, glaciers, scraped across the land and wore everything soft down to mud, but they could not chew through the hard old lump of volcanic rock. So it was left sticking up, a steep crag with a long slope trailing behind it, the perfect place to build a fortress you could see enemies coming from for miles. That is exactly why so many people fought over it. This castle was captured and lost, then captured and lost again, over and over, because whoever held this rock held the key to Scotland.

A Painted Palace and the Kingdom of Unicorns

Most old castles are grey and bare, but Stirling shows you what castles really looked like — and the answer is: loud. The Royal Palace here has been restored to how it looked in the 1540s, when King James the Fifth built it to impress his French wife. The Great Hall is painted golden yellow on the outside — it's called King's Gold, and you can see it glowing from miles away. That's not a modern mistake; that's the real recipe. Inside the palace, costumed people in Tudor dress will chat with you as if it's still 1546 — ask them anything: what's for dinner, where's the toilet, is the king grumpy today. They will not break character. Now, about unicorns. Look for them everywhere: carved, painted, and woven into the huge tapestries of the Hunt of the Unicorn, which took weavers fourteen years to recreate by hand. The unicorn is Scotland's national animal — chosen because legend said the unicorn was proud, brave, and impossible to tame. And its enemy, in old stories? The lion — the symbol of England. That's the joke built into the choice. To this day, the royal coat of arms shows a lion and a unicorn holding the shield together: England and Scotland, ancient rivals, stuck on the same team. The unicorn wears a chain. Scots will tell you: only a chain could hold it.

The Faces in the Ceiling

Go into the King's rooms in the palace and look straight up. The ceiling is covered in giant round carvings of oak wood, each one about as wide as a beach ball, and each one is a face. Kings and queens. Roman emperors from thousands of years ago. Brave heroes from old stories. And, hidden among all the important people, a couple of jokers and jesters, the funny men of the court, pulling faces down at you forever. These wooden portraits are called the Stirling Heads, and they are so precious that people sometimes call them Scotland's other crown jewels.

Now here is the wild part, the true adventure story of the faces. Long ago, in the year 1777, the old ceiling suddenly cracked and came crashing down. The heads were rescued, but then something strange happened. Nobody realized how special they were, so they got scattered all over the place. Some ended up as decorations in people's gardens, sitting outside in the rain. One of them, the story goes, was used as the lid on a butter churn, the machine for making butter. Imagine that. A carved royal face, five hundred years old, being plonked on top of the butter.

For years the heads were lost and forgotten, spread far and wide. Then, slowly, like detectives following clues, people began to track them down and gather them back together, one face at a time. Out of the whole set, they managed to find most of them again, and you can go and meet those very originals in a gallery upstairs. The ones you see up on the ceiling are fresh copies, newly carved and painted in bright colors, so you can see how dazzling the room looked when it was brand new.

That is the big surprise about this whole castle. We think of old places as grey and dusty and quiet. But five hundred years ago, this palace absolutely blazed with color, gold and red and blue and green, everywhere you looked, all designed to make your jaw drop. As you walk through, play a game. Look up in every room. Count the faces staring back at you, and try to guess which ones are the kings, and which ones are the fools who were paid to be funny.

The Golden Hall and the Busy Kitchens

Find the huge building painted glowing yellow gold. That is the Great Hall, and it is the biggest room of its kind in all of Scotland. Step inside and look up again, because the roof is the real wonder. It is made entirely of oak beams, curving up into the dark like the ribs of an enormous upside-down ship, and it was

built without a single supporting pillar in the middle to get in the way. When people first walked in here, that soaring empty roof was meant to make them gasp, and it still works.

This hall was a party room, a place for kings to throw feasts so grand that other kings would hear about them and feel jealous. There were four gigantic fireplaces to keep it warm, tall windows to let the light pour in, and space for hundreds of guests. And that golden color on the outside, called King's Gold, is not a modern mistake. Builders mixed a paint from lime and a yellowish earth, and painted the whole hall that bright glowing shade on purpose, so that travelers could see it gleaming from far across the valley and know that a rich and powerful king lived here. It was like a giant sign saying, look how important I am.

Now, a feast that huge needs a lot of cooking, so go and find the Great Kitchens. This is one of the best bits of the whole castle, because it has been set up to look exactly like a busy day five hundred years ago. There are model cooks everywhere, frozen in the middle of their work. One is plucking a bird. One is stirring an enormous pot. One is hauling a whole deer or a great fish to be roasted. There are baskets piled with pretend food, loaves and eggs and vegetables and slabs of meat, all waiting for a banquet that will now never quite be served.

Picture the noise and the heat of the real thing. Fires roaring, knives chopping, sweaty cooks shouting, dozens of dishes all needing to be ready at the exact same moment for the king next door in his golden hall. Being a cook here was one of the hottest, hardest, busiest jobs in the whole kingdom. Sniff the air, and imagine the smell of five hundred dinners cooking all at once.

A Nine-Month-Old Queen and the Man Who Tried to Fly

Two last Stirling stories. First: in 1543, in the Chapel Royal here, Scotland crowned a new monarch — Mary, Queen of Scots. She was nine months old. She cried through the entire ceremony, and since a baby can't hold a scepter or a giant sword, nobles held each item over her while she wailed. She grew up to have one of the most dramatic lives in history — three husbands, prison escapes, secret codes, and a tragic end — but it all started here, with a crying baby in a crown-sized problem. Second, the legend of the flying man. In 1507, an Italian at the Scottish court named John Damian announced he would fly from Stirling Castle's walls to France. He built himself wings from feathers, climbed the battlements before the whole court, jumped. . . and dropped straight into the muck heap below the walls. He survived — with a broken thigh bone — and his excuse was magnificent: he'd used chicken feathers by mistake, he said, and chickens are drawn to the ground, whereas he should have used eagle feathers. The king kept him at court anyway, possibly because he was so entertaining. Look over the walls at the drop and decide for yourself how lucky he was. Then find the Great Kitchens, where model cooks are frozen mid-feast, preparing a banquet that's been almost ready for five hundred years.

The Flying Abbot and His Wings

Let me tell you the whole story of the man who tried to fly, because it is even better than you think. His name was John Damian, and he came from Italy to work for the King of Scotland, James the Fourth. His real job was not flying. It was something even stranger. He was an alchemist, a kind of magician-scientist who promised he could turn ordinary metal into pure gold. The king loved that idea, obviously, and gave Damian a workshop with roaring furnaces, right here in the castle, where he boiled and mixed and burned things for years, trying to brew a magic liquid that would make everyone rich. It never worked. Not once. But the king kept paying, and paying.

Then, in the year 1507, Damian announced his most daring plan yet. He would build himself a pair of wings and fly, he said, all the way across the sea to France, faster than any messenger could ride. He gathered feathers, strapped on his home-made wings, and climbed up onto the high castle walls while the whole court gathered below to watch. Imagine the crowd, whispering, pointing, half sure he would soar like an eagle.

He jumped. And he dropped like a stone, straight down, and landed with a splat in the midden. Now, a midden is the castle rubbish heap, the place where they threw all the kitchen scraps and, well, the toilet waste too. So he did not just fall. He fell into a giant pile of poo. And he broke his thigh bone, the big bone in his leg.

But here is why we still tell the story. Damian had an excuse ready, and it is magnificent. It was not his fault, he insisted. The problem was the feathers. Some of them, he said, had come from hens, from ordinary chickens, and everyone knows chickens cannot fly and love to scratch about in the dirt. So naturally those feathers had dragged him down into the muck. If only he had used proper eagle feathers, he would have flown to France, no trouble at all.

There was a poet at the court named William Dunbar who thought this was the funniest thing he had ever seen, and he wrote a mocking poem about it, pretending that all the birds of the sky attacked the flying man and knocked him out of the air. That poem still survives, which means people have been giggling at John Damian for over five hundred years. Look over the wall, spot the long drop, and be very glad you have never landed in a castle midden.

The Baby Prince's Fireworks Party

You already know that a baby was crowned queen in this castle. Well, this castle was also where kings threw the most spectacular baby parties in Scottish history. Not birthday parties. Baptisms, the special ceremony when a baby is welcomed and named. And royal ones were wild.

In the year 1566, the baby prince James, the son of Mary Queen of Scots, was baptized right here. To celebrate, they put on something Scotland had never seen before. Fireworks. Real, whooshing, banging, sparkling fireworks, lighting up the night sky over the castle. It was, as far as anyone can tell, the very first proper firework display in the whole country. Picture the crowds gasping and pointing at the exploding colors, having never in their lives seen anything like it.

That baby James grew up to become king, and years later he threw a baptism party of his own for his little boy, Prince Henry, in the year 1594. And this one may be the most extraordinary feast ever held in that golden Great Hall. When it was time for the fish course, the doors swung open and in came, not a waiter with a tray, but an enormous model sailing ship. It was as long as a bus, eighteen feet, with real masts and rigging soaring high overhead, and it was loaded with all the fish for the feast. And to announce its grand arrival, the little ship fired its cannons. Actual cannons, going bang, indoors, at dinner.

But here is my favorite part, the plan that was almost even crazier. The very first course was meant to be pulled into the hall on a fancy chariot. And do you know what they wanted to pull that chariot? A real, live lion. A genuine lion, harnessed up, hauling a wagon full of food between the tables. Then somebody, thank goodness, stopped and thought about it. What if the lion got frightened by all the noise and the crowds? Or worse, what if the guests got frightened by the lion? So at the last minute they called off the lion and had a person guide the chariot in instead, with the wheels moved by a hidden machine so it seemed to roll along by magic.

So remember, when you stand in that quiet golden hall, that once it was full of fireworks and cannon fire and a ship the size of a bus, and very nearly a lion, all to celebrate one small baby. Kings really did know how to throw a party.

Mary's Great Escape

The baby who cried through her own coronation grew up to have a life so full of danger and adventure that it sounds like a made-up movie, except every bit of it really happened. Her name, of course, was Mary Queen of Scots, and here is what became of her.

When she was still tiny, only five years old, powerful people in England wanted to grab her and marry her off, so to keep her safe her family smuggled her across the sea to France. She grew up there as a French princess, and she grew up tall, nearly six feet, which was like a giant back then, and clever, able to speak five different languages. But when she sailed home to Scotland as a young woman, everything went wrong, one thing after another.

One evening her private secretary was dragged away and murdered right in front of her, while she was expecting a baby. Then her own husband's house was blown up in the middle of the night, and he was found dead in the garden. It was a mystery worthy of a detective story, and Mary was never safe again. Her enemies took away her crown and forced her to hand it to her baby son, that same little James who had the firework party.

Then came her most famous adventure. Mary was locked up as a prisoner in a castle on an island in the middle of a lake. Escape looked impossible. But she made friends with a boy who worked there, got hold of the keys, disguised herself, slipped down to the water, and rowed away across the loch in a little boat in the dark. She was free. She raised a whole army in about a week, though sadly she lost the battle that followed, and fled to England to beg her cousin, Queen Elizabeth, for help.

Elizabeth did not help. Instead she kept Mary a prisoner for nineteen long years. And Mary, being clever to the very end, spent those years sewing beautiful embroidery stitched with secret hidden messages, and sending coded letters smuggled out inside barrels of beer. Sadly, her enemies cracked the code, and that was the end of her story.

But not the end of her family. Her son James grew up to become king of Scotland and England, both at once, the first person ever to rule the two countries together. So the crying baby crowned in this castle became the ancestor of kings and queens right down to today. Every British monarch since is her descendant. Not bad for a girl who once escaped a castle in a rowing boat.